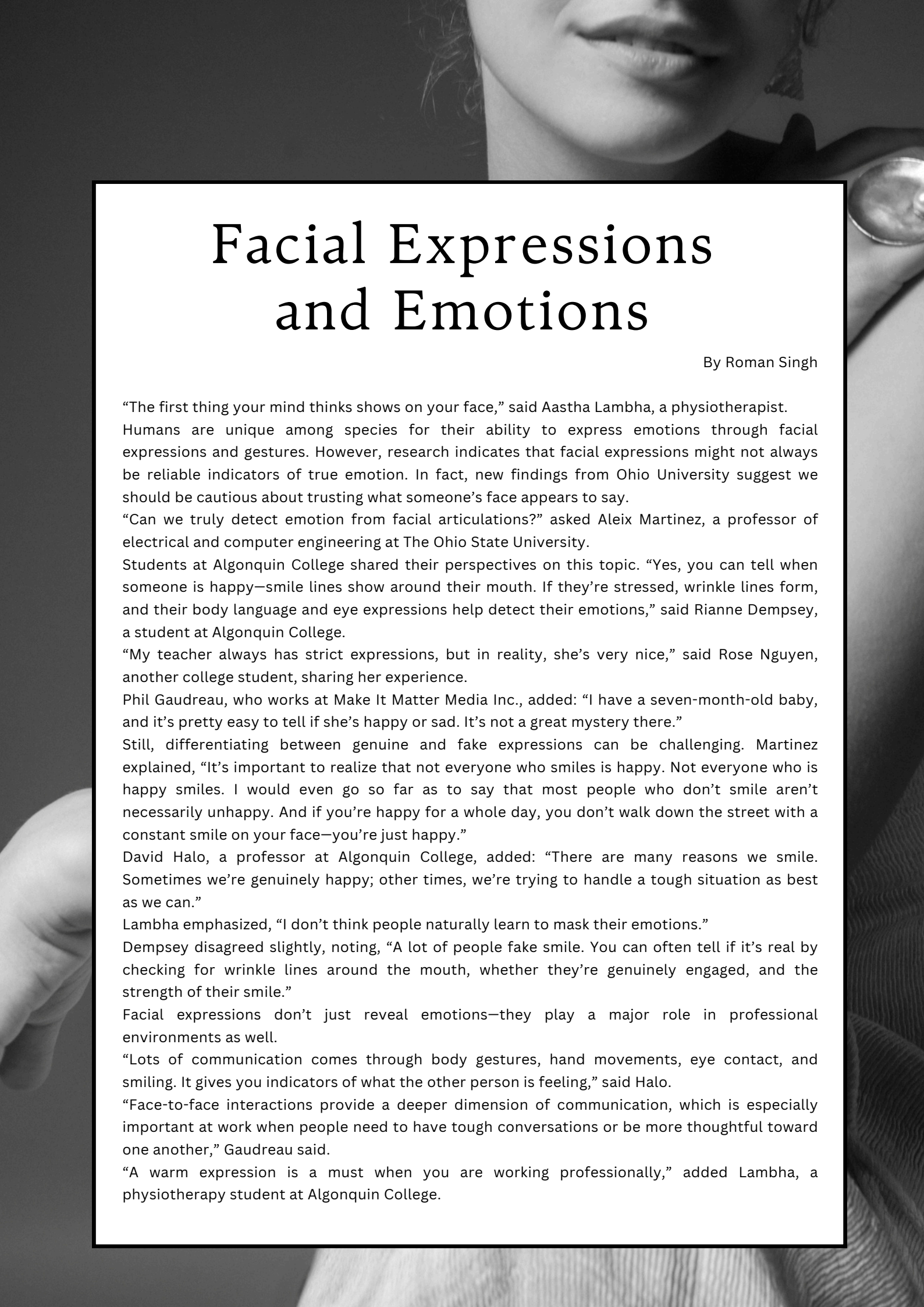




Facial Expressions and Emotions

By Roman Singh

“The first thing your mind thinks shows on your face,” said Aastha Lambha, a physiotherapist.

Humans are unique among species for their ability to express emotions through facial expressions and gestures. However, research indicates that facial expressions might not always be reliable indicators of true emotion. In fact, new findings from Ohio University suggest we should be cautious about trusting what someone’s face appears to say.

“Can we truly detect emotion from facial articulations?” asked Aleix Martinez, a professor of electrical and computer engineering at The Ohio State University.

Students at Algonquin College shared their perspectives on this topic. “Yes, you can tell when someone is happy—smile lines show around their mouth. If they’re stressed, wrinkle lines form, and their body language and eye expressions help detect their emotions,” said Rianne Dempsey, a student at Algonquin College.

“My teacher always has strict expressions, but in reality, she’s very nice,” said Rose Nguyen, another college student, sharing her experience.

Phil Gaudreau, who works at Make It Matter Media Inc., added: “I have a seven-month-old baby, and it’s pretty easy to tell if she’s happy or sad. It’s not a great mystery there.”

Still, differentiating between genuine and fake expressions can be challenging. Martinez explained, “It’s important to realize that not everyone who smiles is happy. Not everyone who is happy smiles. I would even go so far as to say that most people who don’t smile aren’t necessarily unhappy. And if you’re happy for a whole day, you don’t walk down the street with a constant smile on your face—you’re just happy.”

David Halo, a professor at Algonquin College, added: “There are many reasons we smile. Sometimes we’re genuinely happy; other times, we’re trying to handle a tough situation as best as we can.”

Lambha emphasized, “I don’t think people naturally learn to mask their emotions.”

Dempsey disagreed slightly, noting, “A lot of people fake smile. You can often tell if it’s real by checking for wrinkle lines around the mouth, whether they’re genuinely engaged, and the strength of their smile.”

Facial expressions don’t just reveal emotions—they play a major role in professional environments as well.

“Lots of communication comes through body gestures, hand movements, eye contact, and smiling. It gives you indicators of what the other person is feeling,” said Halo.

“Face-to-face interactions provide a deeper dimension of communication, which is especially important at work when people need to have tough conversations or be more thoughtful toward one another,” Gaudreau said.

“A warm expression is a must when you are working professionally,” added Lambha, a physiotherapy student at Algonquin College.